the RSS leaders have done is train the spotlight back on the jobs crisis. BJP leaders, though, are trying to make light of the criticism, saying Hosabale's comments are nothing new, and that "these challenges were raised in speeches by the PM himself".

The *sarkaryavah*, though, has taken it a step further, comparing poverty in the country to a "demon standing in front of us". "It is important that we slay this demon. That 20 crore [200 million] people are still below the poverty line is a figure that should make us very sad. As many as 23 crore [230 million] make less than Rs 375 a day," Hosabale said while speaking at a webinar organised by RSS affiliate Swadeshi Jagran Manch (SJM) as part of its Swavalambi Bharat Abhiyan (self-help India campaign) to create jobs and self-employment opportunities. SJM and eight other RSS affiliates are collaborating on the campaign.

The *sarkaryavah*'s comments on inequality and the widespread unemployment were a reality check. He argued that the top 1 per cent of India's population had cornered one-fifth (20 per cent) of the nation's income while "50 per cent has only 13 per cent of the income". On the jobs crisis, the RSS leader added: "Four crore [40 million] people are unemployed in the country. The labour force survey says we have an unemployment rate of 7.6 per cent."

In 2019, the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) for 2017-18 found that unemployment had hit a 45-year high of 6.1 per cent, but the Modi government flatly refused to accept the findings. The then NITI Aayog CEO Amitabh Kant had even hurriedly held a press conference to argue that India cannot be growing at over 7 per cent without creating jobs. But was it creating enough jobs?

For the longest time, the BJP and alma mater RSS have been at cross-purposes in their economic worldview. While the BJP-led governments promoted neo-liberal economic policies and the opening up of the economy for foreign investment, the RSS was conservative, making the case for Indian entrepreneurs getting preference and economic modules that were labour-intensive. The RSS's inhouse economist and SJM national co-convenor Ashwani Mahajan, who has been articulating the Sangh affiliate's economic views since 2014, has been a trenchant critic of the "jobless growth model". He argues that the situation described by Hosabale is a product of the liberalisation initiated in 1991. "This situation did not arise overnight," he adds. "The government policies are now trying to to achieve the Antyodaya targets, which will require some timely tweaks. We flag the issues that we find and they too consider our suggestions."

> **"Over 4 crore people do not have jobs. The labour force survey says we have an unemployment rate of 7.6%"**
>
> **–DATTATREYA HOSABALE**
> *RSS sarkaryavah*



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While the government machinery is on overdrive to paint rosy growth numbers—India's GDP grew by 8.7 percent the previous fiscal and is expected to grow at 7 per cent in 2022-23—the rebound has to be seen in the light of the GDP contraction and the low base earlier, first due to the 2019-20 slowdown and later due to Covid-related restrictions. In fact, estimates infer that the key metrics—poverty, inequality and unemployment—are not getting better.

Meanwhile, Bhagwat also mentioned the Swavalambi Bharat Abhiyan in his address, the groundwork for which has apparently started in 600 of the 773 districts in the country. District-level Rojgar Srijan Kendras, which links entrepreneurs to financial institutions to start their own ventures, are already functioning in 275 districts. The campaign will tie up with local academic institutions, government agencies and provide knowledge, skills and some level of handholding. "A common problem is that the unemployed are not getting jobs, and the industries suitable talent. We are trying to bridge this," says Satish Kumar, the SJM national joint organising secretary who is anchoring the entire programme.

RSS affiliates like the SJM, BMS (Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh) and BKS